Project 3: Google Doodles 2024

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VDES24178 Visual Design and Computation

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Design statement

The Jack-o'-Lantern Doodle represents the journey of how a folk legend evolved into a global cultural symbol, exploring themes of cultural adaptation, image transformation, and the joyful spirit of Halloween. These themes are visually brought to life through interactive glowing pumpkin letters, wandering ghosts, fluttering bats, and a hauntingly moonlit backdrop.

The central pumpkin serves as the primary vessel for cultural memory. The evolution of the “google” label within the pumpkin suggests its transformation from a natural fruit to a cultural artifact. The surrounding ghosts and bats are not mere decorations but echoes of folklore. I aimed to anchor the animation's visuals in the traditional Halloween practice of interacting with the spirit world. Thus, I employed an overall dark yet whimsical Gothic style throughout the animation. Simultaneously, I aimed to fuse the eerie origins of the legend with its modern symbol of festive Halloween joy. This short animation represents a visual narrative that is both an origin story and a celebration of the holiday.

Synopsis of the Theme

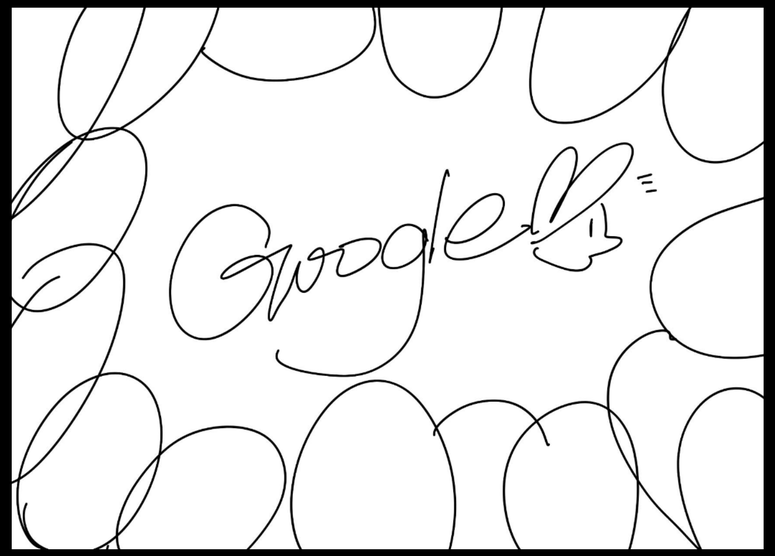
The theme chosen for this project commemorates the origins and evolution of the Jack-o'-lantern. I believe it holds profound cultural significance, rooted in folklore, immigrant history, and collective celebration. This rich historical context provided abundant inspiration for my animation creation. Initially, I intended to create a Halloween commemorative Google Doodle, but as my research into Halloween deepened, I discovered this historical tale. Upon learning this tale, I felt it was exceptionally well-suited for animation.

This tradition stems from an Irish folk tale about “Stingy Jack.” Cursed to wander the earth forever, he carries a lantern made from a hollowed-out turnip lit by a coal, becoming the ghostly “Jack-o'-Lantern.” . When immigrants brought this legend to North America, locally abundant, larger, and easier-to-carve pumpkins naturally replaced turnips. This transformed a regional ghost tale into a vibrant, hands-on autumn ritual. Thus, the jack-o'-lantern itself embodies a journey: from an Old World cautionary myth, to an adaptive practice born on new soil, to becoming a universal symbol of Halloween revelry today.

Therefore, in designing the animation, I aimed for the pumpkin to represent the legend's evolution itself. Elements like ghosts and bats directly reference the supernatural realm of the original tale. They also pay homage to Mary Shelley, the mother of Gothic literature and science fiction. It is precisely this darkly whimsical Gothic style that bridges the gap between its eerie origins and the festive atmosphere of modern celebrations. By simply animating this story, I hope to bring its vibrant history to life for a wider audience.

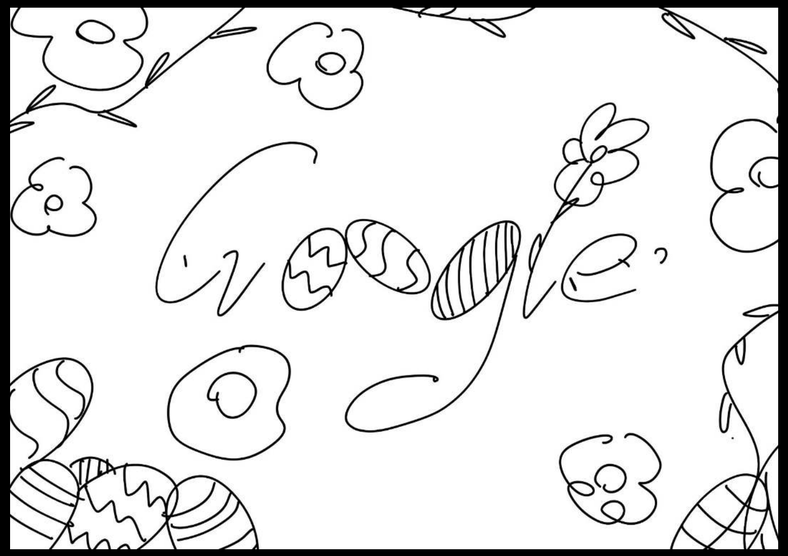
Process work

Topic: Easter - Resurrection Egg



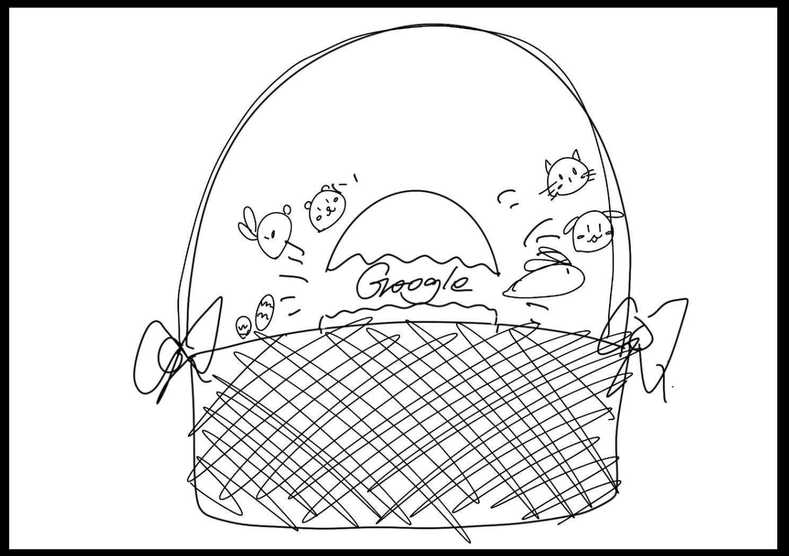
Sketch 1
The background features a “circular Easter egg outline.” The Google logo is integrated within it, creating a clean overall layout that directly references the Easter theme through “egg + rabbit” elements.

Topic: Easter - Egg transporter: Rabbit



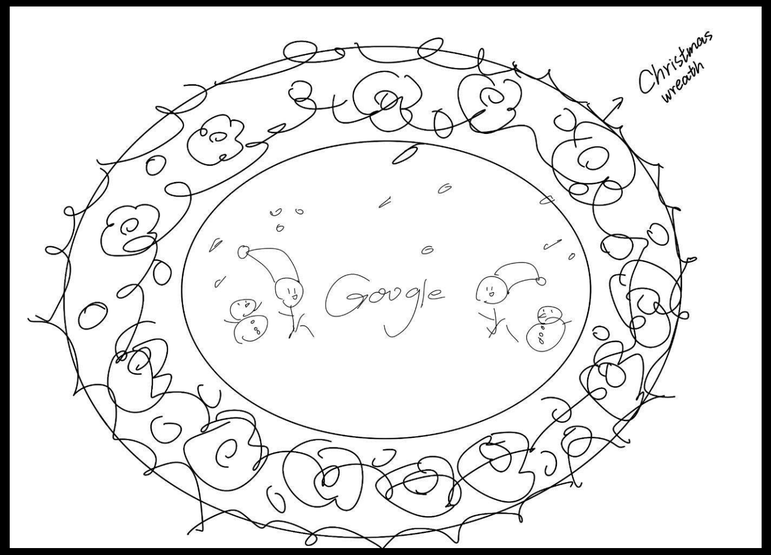
Sketch 2
The background features grass, small flowers, and branches. The letters of the Google logo are combined with “decorated eggs.” The “o” and “g” become Easter eggs, the ‘l’ incorporates floral branch elements, and the “e” letter directly transforms into a small rabbit shape. Textured Easter eggs are stacked at the bottom of the logo, creating a natural grassy atmosphere.

Topic: Easter - The little surprise in the basket



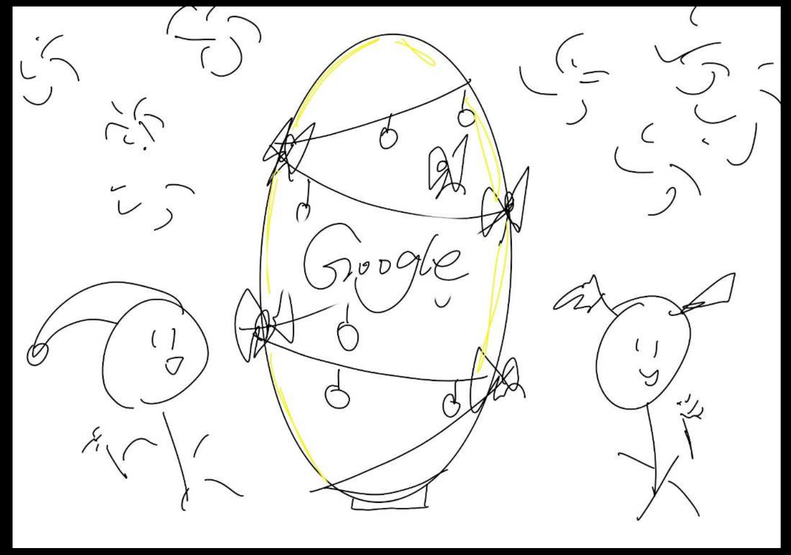
Sketch 3
The main element is a basket with a woven texture. Inside the basket lies a “cracked Easter egg,” from which the Google logo emerges. Simultaneously, small animals like bunnies and hamsters (with motion trails) “fly out” of the egg alongside the logo. I aim to convey the playful dynamic of “eggs hatching.”

Topic: Christmas - Christmas wreath



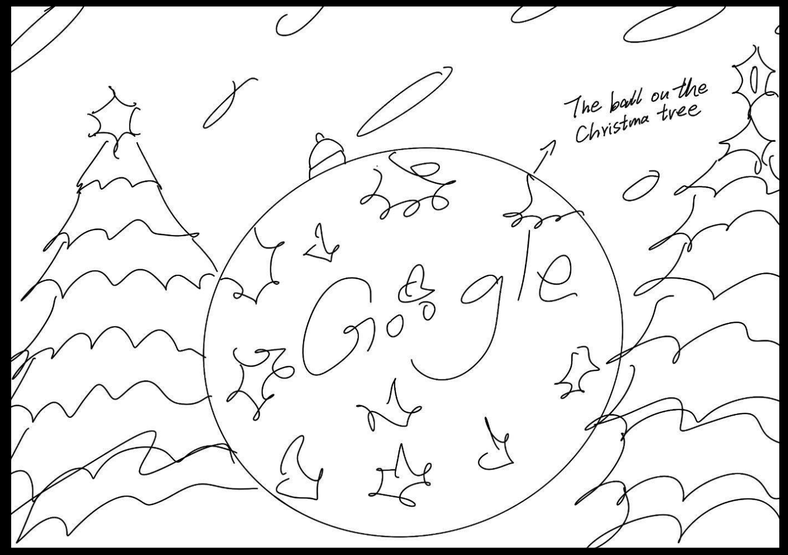
Sketch 4
The core element is an “oval Christmas wreath.” Inside the wreath is the Google logo, along with two children wearing Santa hats, each accompanied by a small snowman. I envision dynamic snowflakes falling throughout the scene.

Topic: Christmas -Christmas tree



Sketch 5
The main element is a “giant light bulb (simulating a Christmas tree)” adorned with decorative ornaments and bows. The Google logo hangs as a decoration on this bulb tree. Two children stand on either side, with fireworks exploding in the background. I want to convey a scene of “Christmas tree + festive interaction.”

Topic: Christmas - Christmas decorations



Sketch 6
The main element is a “round Christmas ornament” adorned with stars and floral branches, with the Google logo integrated into the sphere. Two small Christmas tree decorations flank the sides. Falling decorative elements appear in the background.

Topic: Halloween - Ghost



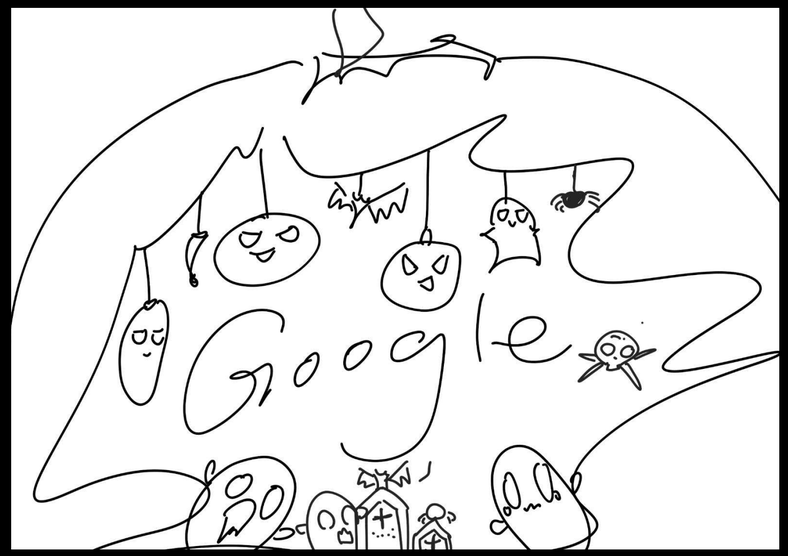
Sketch 7
The main element is a “large pumpkin” with the Google logo inside its mouth. The pumpkin is surrounded by several smiling ghosts, with flowers sprouting around them. I want to convey a cute Halloween atmosphere.

Topic: Halloween - Moon

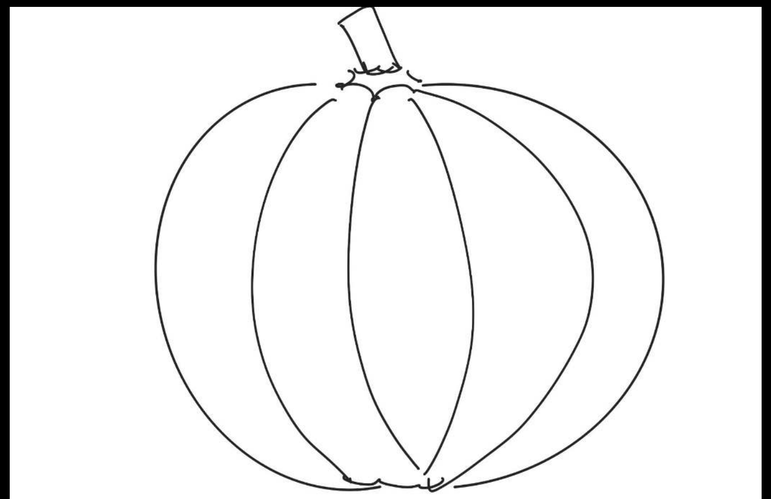


Sketch 8
The background features a “black moon silhouette (large tree branches)” with multiple pumpkins scattered below. Two skeleton balloons float in the center, surrounded by flying bats. I aim to recreate an “outdoor Halloween scene under moonlight.”

Topic: Halloween - Pumpkin party



Sketch 9
The main element is a “Hollowed-Out Giant Pumpkin”; inside the pumpkin hang little ghosts, bats, and spiders (with hanging lines), with tombstone decorations at the bottom. The Google logo sits in the center of the pumpkin, while the little ghosts display various expressions (happy, playful). The overall scene depicts a “Little Ghost Party Inside the Pumpkin.”



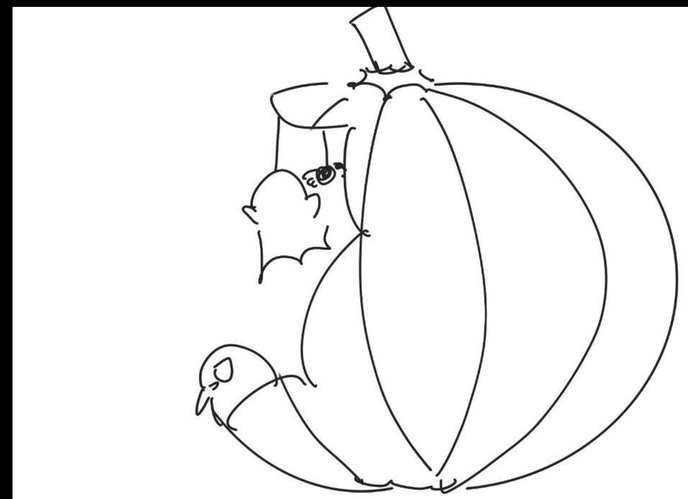
Screen 1

0-3 seconds: Mysterious Beginning

Visual: A whole round pumpkin with natural vertical ridges rests against a pure black background. Dim light barely outlines its silhouette.

Sound/Atmosphere: Faint ambient wind or distant chimes may suggest an ancient, mysterious ambiance.

Purpose: Suggest the pumpkin is no ordinary vegetable, but a vessel for an unfolding story.



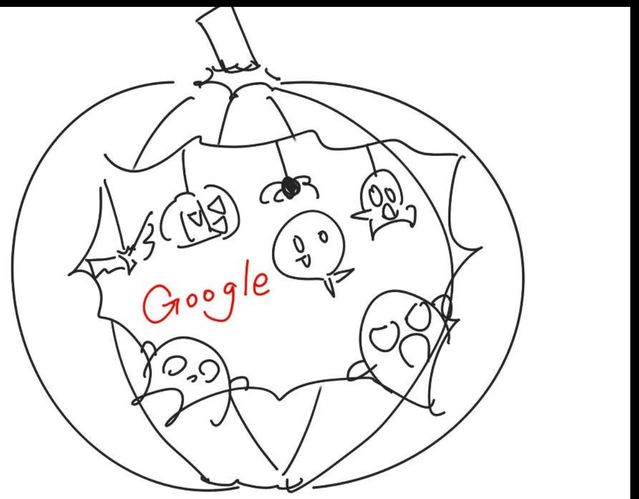
Screen 1

3-6 seconds: Life Emerges

Visual: The pumpkin begins to slowly rotate. At a specific angle, a translucent, adorably shaped little ghost peeks out from the pumpkin's top or side, looking around curiously.

Sound Effects/Interaction: A light, ethereal sound accompanies the ghost's appearance. A brief, warm yellow glow emanates from within the pumpkin. Rotation continues with music.

Purpose: Breaks the static, introducing a supernatural entity. Reveals the pumpkin's hidden depths.



Screen 1

7-9 seconds: Revelry Begins

Visual: The pumpkin's front appears carved by an invisible chisel, its interior glowing warmly. Through the hollowed-out “mouth,” a party of miniature imps, bats, and spiders revels joyfully. Upon closer inspection, the six letters of “Google” are cleverly concealed within the party scene's composition or elements.

Sound/Atmosphere: Giggles of little ghosts and squeaks of bats.

Purpose: Teases the story behind this Jack-o'-Lantern.

Activity Storyboard



Screen 1

10-15 seconds: Logo Emergence and Celebration

Visual: Hidden Google letters gradually “push out” or “emerge” from within the pumpkin, growing clearer and larger as they fly outward. Finally, the complete Google logo, adorned with Halloween-themed decorations, hovers directly in front of the pumpkin. Simultaneously, all internal elements—goblins, bats, etc.—fly out, joyfully circling the pumpkin and logo to create a small visual celebration.

Sound/Interaction: Use resonant background music.

Purpose: Present a fun, resonant animation.

Activity Storyboard



Layout 1 Concept 1



Layout 2 Concept 1



Layout 3 Concept 1



Layout 1 Concept 2



Layout 2 Concept 2



Layout 3 Concept 2

Activity Layout Exercise



Layout 1 Concept 3



Layout 2 Concept 3



Layout 3 Concept 3

Final Design



https://my.spline.design/untitled-HBqgwLUwyWz7uWTPbA0C7G1L/

Tropes



Metaphor
The pumpkin as a “cultural vessel.” The intact pumpkin at the animation's opening, I believe, is not merely an object but a metaphor for untouched, primal folklore and nature. Its warm inner glow and the eventual emergence of the Google logo together symbolize how ancient traditions carry and nurture new, global cultural symbols.

The animation process—ghosts appearing on the pumpkin's surface and its interior being revealed—itself metaphorically represents the core cultural act of “carving.” It doesn't depict physical carving but symbolizes peeling back layers of history to unveil the inner stories and vitality (ghosts, parties).

Metonymy
I believe ghosts and bats embody the “spirit of Halloween.” These animated elements are not incidental decorations but serve as metaphors for Halloween's overarching supernatural and celebratory atmosphere. Their presence directly references the festival's deep cultural roots—its heritage of communicating with the spirit world and celebrating autumn.

The internal party symbolizes “cultural vitality.” The scene of imps partying inside the pumpkin is a metaphor for traditional culture remaining vibrant, communal, and joyful in contemporary times. It demonstrates that this tradition is not a dusty relic, but a continuously flowing, vibrant contemporary practice.

Tropes



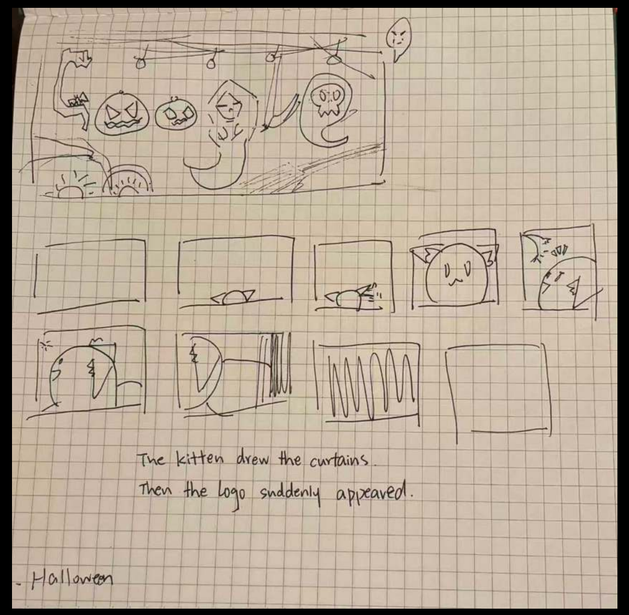
Personification
I aimed to imbue supernatural elements with “personality” and “reaction.” For instance, the peeking ghost was given a curious, mischievous character. The final swirling ghosts were designed with movement trajectories and speeds that radiate joy and revelry. This anthropomorphism transforms abstract concepts like “holiday spirit” and “legendary souls” into relatable, empathetic characters.

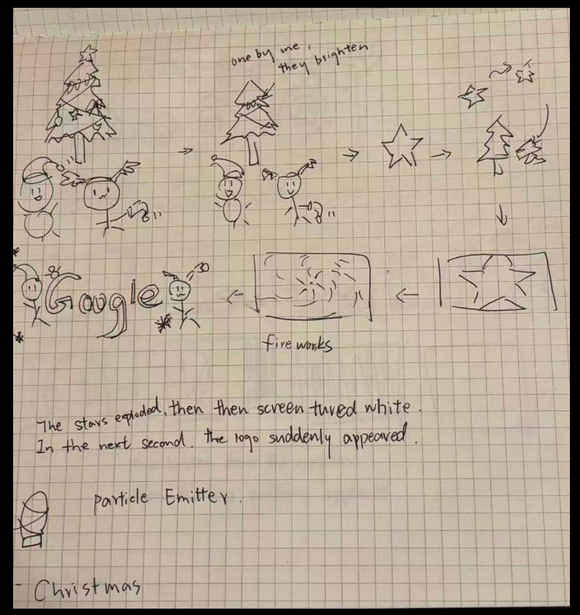
Symbolism
I think the Google logo's journey—from hiding inside the pumpkin to fully emerging and floating in front—symbolizes how modern cultural symbols are born from traditional roots, gain independent identity, and form a new relationship of juxtaposition and dialogue with their source traditions.

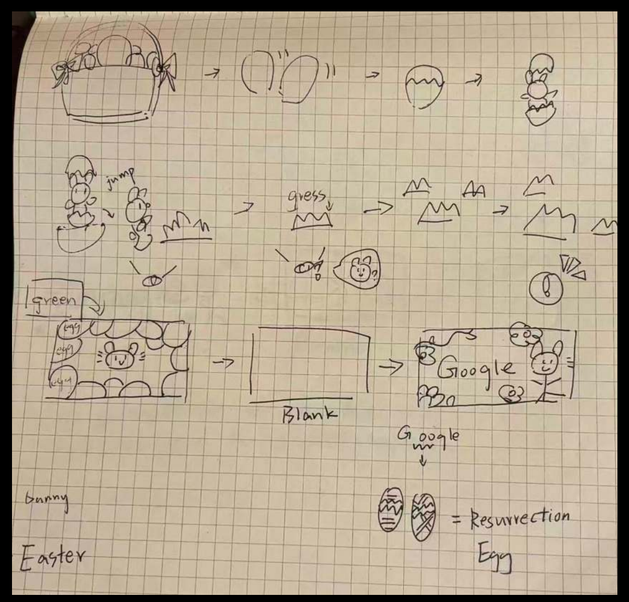
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Appendix







Visual Design **& Computation**

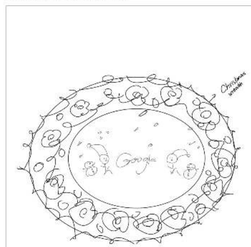
Week **11**

Activity **9 Sketches**

Instructions

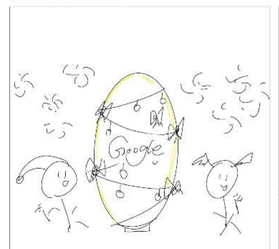
Each sketch is to be based on a topic of interest, one from each of the word clouds.

Topic: Christmas - Christmas wreath



Sketch 1

Topic: Christmas -Christmas tree



Sketch 2

Topic: Christmas - Christmas decorations



Sketch 3

Topic: Halloween - Ghost



Sketch 1

Topic: Halloween - Moon



Sketch 2

Topic: Halloween - Pumpkin party



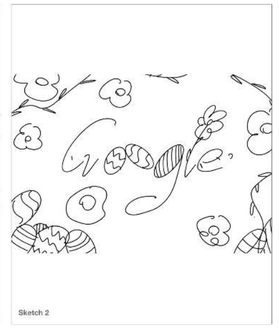
Sketch 3

Topic: Easter - Resurrection Egg



Sketch 1

Topic: Easter - Egg transporter: Rabbit



Sketch 2

Topic: Easter - The little surprise in the basket



Sketch 3

Appendix

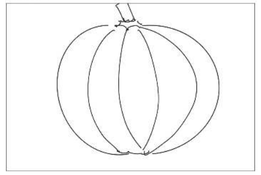
Visual Design **& Computation**

Week **11**

Activity **Storyboard**

Instructions
Complete a short storyboard to show the user might interact or the project animate.
Do you want this to make the user curious? How will you achieve that? How much of the book narrative might you give away?
Is this about driving curiosity or about informing the user? How will the user interact and with what? How will it be animated?

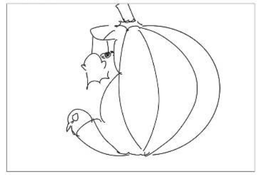
Screen **1**



Description

0-3 seconds
A single, perfectly round pumpkin with natural vertical ridges floats silently against a pitch-black background, devoid of any extraneous elements.

Screen **2**



Description

3-6 seconds
As the pumpkin slowly rotates, a small ghost peeks out from within.

Screen **3**



Description

7-9 seconds
The pumpkin's interior reveals a party scene with imps, bats, spiders, and other elements, while the Google logo is hidden within the pumpkin's center.

Screen **4**



Description

10-15 seconds
The logo slowly emerges from the pumpkin, gradually enlarging until it hovers in front of it. Imps circle around the pumpkin.

Visual Design **& Computation**

Week **11**

Activity **Layout Exercise**

Instructions
Choose layout techniques from those explored in class and experiment with your content

Layout 1 Concept 1



Layout 2 Concept 1



Layout 3 Concept 1



Layout 1 Concept 2



Layout 2 Concept 2



Layout 3 Concept 2



Layout 1 Concept 3



Layout 2 Concept 3



Layout 3 Concept 3



THANK YOU